

STILLKNOCKING IT OUT OF THE PARK

With an **indomitable spirit** and a calm demeanour, Dricus du Plessis has carved his path to the upper echelons of the Ultimate Fighting Championship.

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Born in Ermelo, South Africa, in 1994, Dricus du Plessis' love for fighting started very early. He began training in Judo at the age of five and moved to wrestling and kickboxing before finding his true calling in Mixed Martial Arts.

'Stillknocks', his infamous nickname, carries a touch of irony. Inspired by the insomnia medication, Stilnoct, it was bestowed by his brother after a staggering 30 knockouts in just 33 local circuit fights — an attestation to the raw power that has become his trademark.

From humble beginnings in the South African fighting circuit, du Plessis quickly amassed an impressive record, clinching championship titles in both welterweight and middleweight divisions of the Extreme Fighting Championship — a promotional MMA event. This dominance caught the attention of the UFC, leading to his much-anticipated debut in 2020.

Du Plessis' arrival on the global stage was marked by a series of impressive performances. In March 2021, his second-round knockout win over Trevin Giles earned him a 'Performance of the Night' bonus and firmly established him as a serious contender in the middleweight division.

Du Plessis has built a reputation for his

unorthodox striking, suffocative grappling, and deadly southpaw jabs. Despite being just six fights old in his UFC career, his progression has been nothing short of meteoric.

A testament to this rapid ascent was his recent victory over former middleweight champion Robert Whittaker at UFC 290.

Before the fight, in an interview with *Sportstar*, du Plessis said: "He's not lost to anyone else other than the champion and I'm going to be the first one who's not a champion to beat him." And he kept his word.

Facing seemingly insurmountable odds against a seasoned veteran like

Whittaker, du Plessis silenced the doubters with a comprehensive technical knockout win. His relentless pressure and tactical mastery showcased his evolution as a fighter and highlighted the effectiveness of his eccentric fighting style.

One potential obstacle — breathing issues stemming from a broken nose — was addressed before the Whittaker fight. After undergoing a successful nasal surgery, du Plessis entered the Octagon with an improved breathing pattern and delivered a dominant performance.

With the Whittaker hurdle cleared, du Plessis now gears up for his toughest challenge yet: a middleweight title clash against veteran Sean Strickland at UFC 297 in January. The South African's unwavering drive, combined with his ever-evolving skill set and newfound physical freedom, makes him a formidable opponent for any contender.

Unstoppable: 'Stillknocks', his infamous nickname, carries a touch of irony. Inspired by the insomnia medication, Stilnoct, it was bestowed by his brother after a staggering 30 knockouts in just 33 local circuit fights. GETTY IMAGES

